

Bears receiver Luther Burden expected to miss preseason with groin injury: Source



Bears wide receiver Luther Burden III hurt his groin during one-on-one drills Saturday. Geoff Stellfox / Getty Images



By **Dan Wiederer**

Aug. 10, 2026 | Updated 7:05 pm GMT+3

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Chicago Bears receiver Luther Burden III is likely to miss several weeks with a groin strain, according to a league source who spoke anonymously because they weren't authorized to speak on a sensitive health matter. But Burden should be on target to be available for the Sept. 13 season opener.

Burden is the latest Bears starter to go down with a practice injury during training camp, hurting his groin during one-on-one drills Saturday morning at Halas Hall. On a Caleb Williams pass into the north end zone on Field 3, Burden and cornerback Tyrique Stevenson became tangled up, with both players finishing the rep in discomfort. Stevenson appeared to be in more pain initially, grasping at the region behind his right hip after hitting the ground awkwardly. But he returned to practice and was back in action Sunday as well.

Burden, meanwhile, left Saturday's practice with the training staff and faces a recovery process that will keep him off the practice field on the runway to the regular season.

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The Bears are scheduled to hold a team scrimmage Tuesday afternoon at Halas Hall ahead of their preseason opener at Soldier Field against the Cleveland Browns. Over the next two weeks, the Bears will go on the road for joint practices with the Cincinnati Bengals (Aug. 20) and Tennessee Titans (Aug. 27) ahead of the teams' respective preseason games on the Saturdays of those weeks.

Burden's absence will deprive him of valuable reps and competition as Chicago's offense gears up for the season. Before Saturday's injury, the second-year receiver had been one of the positive standouts in training camp following a productive performance during the Bears spring offseason program as well.

Burden finished his rookie season with 47 catches, 652 yards and two touchdowns and is in line for a heightened role in the offense this season. Bears coach Ben Johnson has been impressed with Burden's work ethic and competitive edge and has been attacking an opening to expand what Burden can do.

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“He was somewhat raw as a route runner when he got here last year,” Johnson said. “And it’s just been slowly developing that route tree. ... When you have a hungry player like that, it makes it a lot of fun because you can introduce new things and he’s got his own little flair to it. The way his body moves, his start and stop, it’s a little bit unique for such a big guy. And that’s what makes it kind of fun.”

Burden’s buy-in has been notable, and his confidence unwavering.

“I expect to have a good, explosive year,” he said. “I feel like it’s gonna be fun to watch.”

That show, however, is temporarily delayed.

Other projected Bears starters sidelined with injuries include Kyler Gordon (calf), Coby Bryant (knee), Montez Sweat (undisclosed), Braxton Jones (undisclosed) and D’Marco Jackson (undisclosed).

Dan Wiederer is a Senior Writer covering the Chicago Bears and the NFL. He has covered the Bears since 2013, previously for the Chicago Tribune, and also covered the Vikings for the Minneapolis Star Tribune. Additionally, Wiederer spent seven seasons covering ACC basketball on Tobacco Road for the Fayetteville (N.C.) Observer. A graduate of the University of Illinois, Wiederer is a multi-time winner of the Chicago Headline Club’s Peter Lisagor Award for Exemplary Journalism. His writing has also been recognized nationally in the Associated Press Sports Editors’ writing contest.

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